Nonlinear hydropower scheduling with coupled hydraulics and delayed river networks

In this article

Physical model
Page 1

Solution and checks
Page 9

Curve equations and bounds
Page 10

Abstract

Short-term hydropower scheduling must decide when to generate and how much water to release. The water available to downstream plants depends on earlier releases and river travel times. Reservoir levels and shared tunnel losses also affect the power obtained from each unit. We formulate the schedule as a mixed-integer nonlinear program with unit commitment, finite gate choices and delayed river transport. Reservoir balances use an implicit midpoint step. Pressure losses and power conversion are nonlinear, and tabulated equipment curves keep their specified interpolants. For fixed river travel times, releases are shifted through the network without averaging at confluences. Distributed delays use interval cohorts and track water still in transit. SCIP searches the full model using feasible starts prepared by mixed-integer proposals and nonlinear dispatch. A separate integration checks the controls on the optimization grid and a finer grid. We state the limits of the resulting objective-gap certificate. The implementation uses Julia and open-source solvers.

1 The scheduling problem

A reservoir can generate now or save water for later. A release lowers its level and changes the energy available from the next release. In a cascade, the water may pass through several plants before leaving the system. The upstream schedule then determines when water becomes available downstream. Shared tunnels impose another dependency, since a plant's discharge affects pressure losses for other plants on the waterway. A unit may be stopped, but when running it must stay within its operating range. These discrete choices and the dependence of generation on head have long been studied together [1].

We take the network, initial volumes, operating histories, prices, inflows, equipment curves and operating limits as given. The optimizer chooses unit states, continuous unit discharges and outlet openings. It selects each adjustable tunnel position from a finite set. The associated volumes, flows, heads, river arrivals and electrical outputs must satisfy the equations below. We maximize generation revenue less operating penalties, with a terminal value for the water left in the system.

We assume deterministic inputs and quasi-steady tunnel hydraulics: pressures and flows are in equilibrium within each scheduling interval while reservoir storage evolves over time. Tunnel inertia and water hammer are excluded. Discharge and travel-time response curves describe the rivers, without solving river momentum equations during scheduling. We do not include pumping, reserves or stochastic decisions.

The optimization uses nonlinear pressure-loss and power equations. Linear approximations provide initial discrete choices for the solution procedure in Section 7.

2 Water balance and hydraulic head

Let $0 = \tau_0 < \cdots < \tau_T$ be time edges in hours, $\Delta_t = \tau_{t+1} - \tau_t$ the interval duration, and $m_t = (\tau_t + \tau_{t+1})/2$ its midpoint, for $t = 0, \ldots, T-1$. Interval inputs are piecewise constant, with changes at these edges. We record volumes at the edges and evaluate the interval hydraulics at midpoint reservoir volumes.

Hydraulic head is mechanical energy per unit weight, expressed in metres. At a reservoir it is the water-surface elevation. At a flooded junction it includes elevation and pressure divided by ρg, where ρ is water density and g is gravitational acceleration. Water flows down a head gradient. Friction

dissipates energy along the waterway, and a turbine can extract power from the flow. The equipment relationships account for velocity corrections and local losses.
Volume is measured in Mm^3 (one million cubic metres, $10^6\mathrm{m}^3$), discharge in $\frac{\mathrm{m}^3}{\mathrm{s}}$ and time in hours. The conversion factors are

$$\kappa = \frac{3600}{10^6} = 0.0036, \quad \gamma = \frac{\rho g}{10^6} = 0.00981 \\ \left(\rho = 1000\frac{\mathrm{kg}}{\mathrm{m}^3}, \quad g = 9.81\frac{\mathrm{m}}{\mathrm{s}^2}\right). \tag{1}$$

Thus $\kappa\Delta q$ converts a discharge over an interval into a volume, and $\gamma q h$ is hydraulic power at discharge q and net head h. For example, a release of $10\frac{\mathrm{m}^3}{\mathrm{s}}$ for one hour removes $0.036\mathrm{Mm}^3$ of water. We use the same conversion for net inflow in the reservoir balance.

Let $\mathcal{R}$, $\mathcal{J}$ and $\mathcal{B}$ index reservoirs, pressure junctions and prescribed-head boundaries. A node n is any of these three. Tunnels, instantaneous channels, generating units and delayed river reaches have index sets $\mathcal{E}$, $\mathcal{C}$, $\mathcal{G}$ and $\mathcal{D}$, respectively. The units at plant p form $\mathcal{G}_p$. Table 1 lists the variables. Underlines and overlines denote supplied lower and upper bounds.

Table 1: Variables and units. Storage and river inventory are recorded at time vertices. The other indexed quantities refer to control intervals.

Variable	Meaning	Unit
V_{it}, W_{rt}	Reservoir volume, river water in transit	Mm^3
H_{nt}, h_{pt}	Node head, turbine net head	m
Q_{et}, X_{ct}, q_{gt}	Tunnel, channel, unit discharge	$\frac{\mathrm{m}^3}{\mathrm{s}}$
R_{rt}, d_{rt}	Reach entry flow, reservoir withdrawal	$\frac{\mathrm{m}^3}{\mathrm{s}}$
A_{rt}	Volume arriving from a delayed reach	Mm^3
P_{gt}	Electrical power	MW
u_{gt}, U_{pt}	Unit and plant operating states	$\{0, 1\}$
b_{et}, a_{rt}	Tunnel position, reservoir outlet opening	$[0, 1]$

Let F_{nt} be net flow into node n from the modeled connections, excluding natural reservoir inflow I_{it}. The matrices B^E, B^C and B^G record the tunnel, channel and unit connections. For a connection between nodes, its column is -1 at the source, $+1$ at the destination, and zero elsewhere. Negative discharge reverses these contributions. Arrival volumes from rivers and withdrawals into them give the remaining terms:

$$F_{nt} = \sum_e B^E_{ne} Q_{et} + \sum_c B^C_{nc} X_{ct} + \sum_g B^G_{ng} q_{gt} + \sum_r D_{nr} \frac{A_{rt}}{\kappa\Delta_t} - \sum_r S_{nr} d_{rt}. \tag{2}$$

$D_{nr} = 1$ if reach r delivers into node n, and $S_{nr} = 1$ if an outlet at n withdraws water into that reach. The other entries are zero. Dividing A_{rt} by $\kappa\Delta_t$ converts arrival volume to flow rate. For a tunnel or plant outfall, F includes the withdrawal from the source node. The outfall enters the river balance below. Its outlet head can depend on a downstream reservoir even though the water reaches that reservoir later (Figure 1).

Water stored at the next time edge equals the present volume plus net inflow over the interval. A pressure junction stores no water, so its net inflow must be zero:

$$V_{i,t+1} - V_{it} = \kappa\Delta_t (I_{it} + F_{it}), \quad V_{i0} = V_i^{\mathrm{init}}. \tag{3}$$

$$F_{jt} = 0 \quad (j \in \mathcal{J}), \quad \underline{V}_{it} \le V_{it} \le \overline{V}_{it} \quad (t = 0, \ldots, T). \tag{4}$$

Initial volumes and volume limits are given data. Junction balances determine how flows meet and divide. Boundary nodes have prescribed heads and may exchange water with the exterior. Reservoir head depends on midpoint volume:

$$H_{it} = Z_i\left(\frac{V_{it} + V_{i,t+1}}{2}\right), \quad \underline{H}_j \le H_{jt} \le \overline{H}_j, \quad H_{bt} = H_b^{\mathrm{given}}. \tag{5}$$

Z_i converts volume to surface elevation. It is an increasing supplied table, or $Z_i(V) = z_i + s_i V + c_i V^2$ with given coefficients. The ending volume is unknown in (3). It also enters (5) and therefore

affects the flow during the interval. We solve these equations as an implicit midpoint step. If Z_i is nonlinear, its value at the average volume is generally different from the average of its endpoint values.

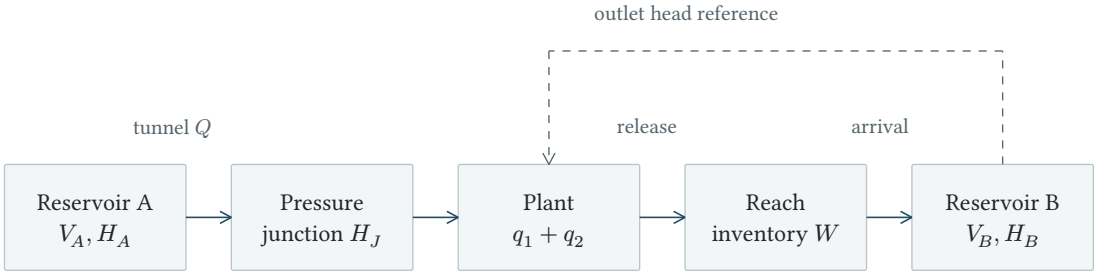


Figure 1: Solid arrows show where the water goes. The dashed connection specifies the plant's outlet head. Water reaches reservoir B after traveling through the river, but B's present level already affects generation.

3 Tunnel hydraulics and generation

3.1 Tunnels and gates

For an oriented tunnel $e = (v, w)$, positive Q_e flows from v to w. With opening $b > 0$, the head difference equals friction loss:

$$H_{vt} - H_{wt} = K_e(b_{et})Q_{et}|Q_{et}|,$$
$$K_e(b) = \begin{cases} \frac{R_e}{b} & \text{without a gate-loss curve} \\ R_e + G_e(b) & \text{with a supplied gate-loss curve.} \end{cases} \tag{6}$$

The tunnel resistance $R_e > 0$ and additional gate resistance $G_e \geq 0$ have units $\frac{\mathrm{s}^2}{\mathrm{m}^5}$. Positive Q requires $H_v > H_w$, and negative Q requires $H_v < H_w$. In either direction, friction dissipates energy with a loss proportional to Q^2. Flows through branches and loops follow from these head equations and the junction balances.

A closed gate permits a head difference while stopping flow:

$$b_{et} = 0 \Longrightarrow Q_{et} = 0, \quad |Q_{et}| \leq C_{et}. \tag{7}$$

Equation (6) applies when the gate is open. Capacity C_{et} bounds flow in either direction. River outfalls that allow only discharge have $Q_{et} \geq 0$. A tunnel position may be prescribed or chosen from a finite set $\mathcal{S}_e \subset [0, 1]$. Prescribed positions may take any value in $[0, 1]$, but the optimizer searches only the listed positions.

An instantaneous channel between reservoirs follows a supplied discharge law:

$$X_{ct} = \Phi_c\big(H_{vt} - H_{wt}, H_{\mathrm{ref},t}\big), \quad |X_{ct}| \leq C_{ct}. \tag{8}$$

Φ_c is a family of curves indexed by a specified upstream or downstream reservoir level. Each curve gives discharge as a function of level difference, is nondecreasing and passes through $(0, 0)$. Positive and negative responses need not be symmetric. We interpolate linearly along each curve and between reference levels. We extend the end segments beyond the tabulated level differences. Outside the reference-level range, we use the nearest curve. Water passes through the channel within the interval, without a separate transit inventory.

3.2 Energy conversion

Write $q_{pt} = \sum_{g \in \mathcal{G}_p} q_{gt}$ and $P_{pt} = \sum_{g \in \mathcal{G}_p} P_{gt}$ for plant totals. All units at a plant share the same net head:

$$h_{pt} = H_{\mathrm{source}(p),t} - \max\Big\{H_{\mathrm{target}(p),t}, h_p^{\mathrm{floor}}\Big\} - T_p\big(q_{pt}\big). \tag{9}$$

The target head is the outlet reference in Figure 1. If an outlet-level floor is specified, the maximum in (9) enforces it. Otherwise we use the target head alone. Total plant discharge raises the tailwater by $T_p\big(q_{pt}\big) \geq 0$. We model shared penstocks as tunnels, whose friction loss depends on the combined discharge of the units they supply.

The binary state u_{gt} selects an idle unit or its running range:

$$u_{gt} \in \{0,1\}, \quad \underline{q}_{gt} u_{gt} \le q_{gt} \le \overline{q}_{gt} u_{gt}, \quad \underline{P}_{gt} u_{gt} \le P_{gt} \le \overline{P}_{gt} u_{gt}. \tag{10}$$

The electrical output is the available hydraulic power multiplied by turbine and electrical efficiencies:

$$P_{gt} = \gamma q_{gt} h_{pt} \eta_g(q_{gt}, h_{pt}) e_g(P_{gt}). \tag{11}$$

When $u_{gt} = 1$, the unit must also satisfy head and efficiency limits and, when supplied by a turbine table, head-dependent discharge limits:

$$\begin{gathered} \underline{h}_g \le h_{pt} \le \overline{h}_g, \quad \eta_g^{\min} \le \eta_g(q_{gt}, h_{pt}) \le 1, \\ q_g^{\mathrm{lo}}(h_{pt}) \le q_{gt} \le q_g^{\mathrm{hi}}(h_{pt}). \end{gathered} \tag{12}$$

When $u_{gt} = 0$, (10) gives $q = P = 0$ and the operating inequalities in (12) are inactive. The plant head is still determined by the hydraulic network, even when none of its units runs.

Turbine efficiency is a supplied table or the analytic relationship

$$\eta_g(q,h) = \eta_g^0 - \alpha_g \left(\frac{q - q_g^*}{q_g^*} \right)^2 - \beta_g \left(\frac{h - h_g^*}{h_g^*} \right)^2. \tag{13}$$

Here q_g^* and h_g^* are reference operating conditions, η_g^0 is their turbine efficiency, and nonnegative α_g, β_g describe its decrease away from them. Tables interpolate linearly in head and either linearly or with shape-preserving cubics in discharge. A single reference head requires an explicit assumption that efficiency and the discharge envelope are independent of head. The actual hydraulic head still enters (11). Operating limits are supplied separately from efficiency knots, with explicit linear continuation required outside the data.

Turbine efficiency converts hydraulic power to shaft power. Electrical efficiency e_g accounts for the remaining conversion to electrical output. It is a separate piecewise-linear function of *electrical output* P, so (11) must be solved for P even when q, h are known. We require $P/e_g(P)$ to be strictly increasing over the admissible output range. The scalar power equation then has at most one admissible solution. If no electrical-efficiency curve is given, $e_g = 1$.

Plant state U_{pt} is one whenever at least one unit runs:

$$U_{pt} \ge u_{gt} \quad (g \in \mathcal{G}_p), \quad U_{pt} \le \sum_{g \in \mathcal{G}_p} u_{gt}, \quad U_{pt} \in \{0,1\}. \tag{14}$$

Plant limits apply to aggregate output and discharge: $P_{pt} \le \overline{P}_{pt}$ and $q_{pt} \le \overline{q}_{pt}$ when supplied, and $P_{pt} \ge \underline{P}_{pt} U_{pt}$, $q_{pt} \ge \underline{q}_{pt} U_{pt}$.

4 Outlets and river transport

4.1 Entry laws, confluences and splits

A river *reach* is a link with a defined entry and downstream destination. For a reach fed by a reservoir outlet, total entry is $R_{rt} = n_{rt} + d_{rt}$: natural reach inflow n plus reservoir withdrawal d. With outlet opening a_{rt}, one chosen law determines withdrawal:

$$d_{rt} = \begin{cases} (C_{rt} - n_{rt}) a_{rt} & \text{controlled outlet} \\ c_r a_{rt} \sqrt{\ell_{rt}} & \text{orifice} \\ c_r \ell_{rt}^{\frac{3}{2}} & \text{uncontrolled weir} \\ a_{rt} D_r\left(H_{\mathrm{source}(r),t}\right) & \text{supplied discharge curve.} \end{cases} \tag{15}$$

ℓ is the head above the outlet crest, $H_{\mathrm{source}} - z_r^{\mathrm{crest}}$. It must be nonnegative unless dry operation is allowed, in which case we use $[H_{\mathrm{source}} - z_r^{\mathrm{crest}}]_+$, with $[x]_+ = \max(x, 0)$. The coefficient c_r or curve D_r is supplied. An uncontrolled weir has $a = 1$, also when its law is given as a table. Other openings satisfy their bounds in $[0, 1]$. Ordinary reaches obey $n_{rt} \le R_{rt} \le C_{rt}$. The reservoir loses $d = R - n$. Natural reach inflow enters the river directly and must not be subtracted from reservoir storage.

The square-root derivative is singular at a dry outlet. Local dispatch instead uses $w \geq 0$ with $w^2 \geq \ell$ and $w(w^2 - \ell) = 0$. These polynomial constraints give exactly $w = \sqrt{[\ell]_+}$, so withdrawal is caw or cw^3. The global model uses a binary positive-part graph followed by $w^2 = [\ell]_+$. Both formulations retain the crest boundary without smoothing the physical law.

The analytic outlet laws are one-level responses; they do not calculate downstream backwater or gate geometry. A supplied response must include those effects where needed. Tunnel connections assume submerged entrances and exits.

At a zero-storage river node, incoming water is distributed among outgoing reaches with prescribed shares α_r. Local natural inflow and plant or tunnel outfalls enter each branch after this allocation. Let L_{rt} collect these local injections:

$$L_{rt} = n_{rt} + \sum_{g \to r} q_{gt} + \sum_{e \to r} Q_{et}, \quad R_{rt} = L_{rt} + \alpha_r \sum_{s \to r} \frac{A_{st}}{\kappa \Delta_t}. \tag{16}$$

Here $g \to r$ and $e \to r$ identify local outfalls, while $s \to r$ identifies reaches arriving at the source node of r. At every zero-storage node, $0 \leq \alpha_r \leq 1$ and the outgoing shares sum to one. These supplied constants hold throughout the horizon. A confluence with one outgoing reach has $\alpha_r = 1$. A 40% branch receiving 5 m³/s upstream and 1 m³/s locally carries 3 m³/s. Its capacity must accommodate both sources; spare capacity on another branch cannot change the prescribed split. Delayed reaches form a directed acyclic network, so we propagate arrivals in upstream order. Tunnels and instantaneous channels may form loops.

4.2 Release cohorts and travel-time responses

A *cohort* is the water entering a reach during one release interval. With a fixed travel time, that release simply appears downstream later. With a distributed delay, different fractions of the cohort arrive at different times. The response functions are deterministic approximations of river transport [2].

For reference entry flow ρ_{rj}, let fraction $w_{rj\ell}$ have a travel time uniformly distributed over $\left[\delta_{rj\ell}, \delta_{rj,\ell+1}\right]$. Delay edges must be nonnegative and strictly increasing. The fractions obey $w_{rj\ell} \geq 0$ and $\sum_\ell w_{rj\ell} = 1$. The cumulative fraction that has arrived after elapsed time s is

$$F_{rj}(s) = \sum_\ell w_{rj\ell} \min\left\{1, \max\left\{0, \frac{s - \delta_{rj\ell}}{\delta_{rj,\ell+1} - \delta_{rj\ell}}\right\}\right\}. \tag{17}$$

Entry flow may change the travel response. For two or more nonnegative, strictly increasing reference flows covering zero through reach capacity, interpolate between the neighboring distributions. A missing zero-flow reference is rejected. Zero flow releases no water. In the following equations, SOS2 is a *special ordered set of type 2*: at most two weights may be nonzero, and their indices must be adjacent.

$$\theta_{rkj} \geq 0, \quad \sum_j \theta_{rkj} = 1, \quad R_{rk} = \sum_j \rho_{rj} \theta_{rkj}, \quad \theta_{rk} \in \mathrm{SOS2}\,. \tag{18}$$

The weights reproduce the cohort's total entry flow, including natural inflow and upstream arrivals. For example, halfway between two reference flows, the two distributions receive equal weights. A single distribution needs only $\theta_{rk1} = 1$. We then omit the flow-reproduction equation, so the reference flow does not fix the release. Once released, each cohort keeps its chosen mixture. Reference flows are calibration data and are unaffected by changes in operating capacity.

Consider water entering at time s in interval k. The fraction of it arriving during interval t is the cumulative fraction at age $\tau_{t+1} - s$ minus that at age $\tau_t - s$. Averaging over the release interval gives

$$B_{rtkj} = \frac{1}{\Delta_k} \int_{\tau_k}^{\tau_{k+1}} \left[F_{rj}(\tau_{t+1} - s) - F_{rj}(\tau_t - s)\right] \mathrm{d}s. \tag{19}$$

Multiplying by released volume and summing over cohorts gives arrival volume A_{rt}:

$$A_{rt} = A_{rt}^{\mathrm{hist}} + \kappa \sum_k \Delta_k R_{rk} \sum_j \theta_{rkj} B_{rtkj}. \tag{20}$$

Water arriving at clock time s from cohort k must have a travel time between $s - \tau_{k+1}$ and $s - \tau_k$. Integrating the delay density over this range gives the difference of cumulative fractions below. Multiplying by the cohort's release rate gives its contribution to instantaneous arrival rate:

$$f_r(s) = f_r^{\text{hist}}(s) + \sum_k R_{rk} \sum_j \theta_{rkj} \big[F_{rj}(s - \tau_k) - F_{rj}(s - \tau_{k+1})\big]. \tag{21}$$

The historical terms account for releases before τ_0. We evaluate the integrals exactly for the uniform bins. Since θ depends linearly on R within a reference-flow interval, multiplying the arrival fraction by released volume gives a quadratic dependence on R. Interpolating arrival volumes directly would give a different travel response.

When all reaches have fixed travel times $\delta_r \geq 0$, we propagate the piecewise-constant entry stream $\tilde{R}_r(s)$ through the network. Each reach shifts its stream by its delay. At a river node, each outgoing stream receives its share of the shifted upstream streams:

$$\begin{gathered} f_r(s) = \tilde{R}_r(s - \delta_r), \quad \tilde{R}_r(s) = L_r(s) + \alpha_r \sum_{s' \to r} f_{s'}(s), \\ A_{rt} = \kappa \int_{\tau_t}^{\tau_{t+1}} f_r(s)\, \mathrm{d}s. \end{gathered} \tag{22}$$

The allocation relation applies for $s \geq 0$. At a reservoir source, $\tilde{R}_r(s) = n_{rt} + d_{rt}$ on $[\tau_t, \tau_{t+1})$. For $s < 0$, it is the independently supplied entry history of that reach, already allocated to its branch. Upstream historical water arriving at a node after zero is allocated once, on entry to the outgoing reaches. Interval entry variables are the averages of these streams:

$$R_{rt} = \frac{1}{\Delta_t} \int_{\tau_t}^{\tau_{t+1}} \tilde{R}_r(s)\, \mathrm{d}s. \tag{23}$$

For example, a one-hour release passing through two reaches with half-hour delays must arrive as a one-hour release shifted by one hour. On an hourly mixing grid, averaging after the first reach would spread some arrival before and after that final interval. A release can reach downstream within its control interval when the delay is zero or shorter than that interval. We check entry capacities on the stream, including both sides of each jump.

If any reach has a distributed delay, (16) instead uses the mean upstream arrivals as the next reach's interval release. Equations (19) and (20) are exact for those rectangular cohorts, but this downstream averaging approximates the continuous timing. We assess this error on a finer transport grid by comparing cumulative arrivals and water in transit. A volume balance cannot detect water that arrives at the wrong time.

4.3 Water in transit, history and environmental flows

Water released but not yet delivered belongs to reach inventory W. Its change equals entry volume minus arrival volume:

$$W_{r,t+1} = W_{rt} + \kappa \Delta_t R_{rt} - A_{rt}, \quad W_{r0} = W_r^{\text{hist}}. \tag{24}$$

Pre-horizon entry records determine both initial inventory and future historical arrivals. For a past cohort k released on $[s_k, e_k)$, let F_k be its selected delay mixture. Water released at $s < 0$ has age $-s$ at the horizon start, so the fraction still in transit is $1 - F_k(-s)$:

$$W_r^{\text{hist}} = \kappa \sum_{k \in \mathcal{H}_r} R_{rk} \int_{s_k}^{e_k} [1 - F_k(-s)]\, \mathrm{d}s. \tag{25}$$

The historical cohorts of reach r form $\mathcal{H}_r$. We assume zero entry before the supplied history. A reach's records already include past upstream contributions, so propagating them again would count the water twice. To restart after executing part of a schedule, we save its entry cohorts and flows as well as reservoir states and operating histories. Average arrivals alone cannot determine when the water still in transit will arrive.

Summing reservoir and reach balances cancels every internal transfer:

$$\begin{aligned} &\sum_i (V_{i,t+1} - V_{it}) + \sum_r (W_{r,t+1} - W_{rt}) \\ &\quad = \kappa \Delta_t \left(\sum_i I_{it} + \sum_r n_{rt} + E_t \right). \end{aligned} \tag{26}$$

Here E_t is net boundary exchange, positive into the modeled system. For a plant outfall, the source reservoir loses q and the reach receives it. Arrival A later leaves the reach and enters the receiving reservoir. Both transfers cancel in the sum. Total stored and in-transit water changes only through natural inflows and external exchanges, including when an instantaneous connection carries reversed flow.

Environmental requirements can constrain reach entry $R_{rt} \geq R_{rt}^{\min}$, average arrival over a specified time window J, or arrival at every instant:

$$\int_J f_r(s)\,\mathrm{d}s \geq \int_J f_r^{\min}(s)\,\mathrm{d}s, \quad f_r(s) \geq f_r^{\min}(s). \tag{27}$$

The supplied policy chooses the window or pointwise arrival constraint. Distributed arrival rates from rectangular cohorts are piecewise linear. Fixed-delay streams are piecewise constant. Between combined response and requirement breakpoints, the difference $f_r - f_r^{\min}$ is affine, so its minimum occurs at an endpoint. It is enough to check these endpoints, taking both one-sided limits at a jump. At the horizon endpoints, use the limit from inside the horizon.

An aggregate flow requirement can also combine named unit discharges, river entries, channel flows and a given inflow contribution I_{ot}:

$$\sum_{g \in \mathcal{G}_o} q_{gt} + \sum_{r \in \mathcal{D}_o \cup \mathcal{C}_o} R_{rt} + I_{ot} \geq M_{ot}. \tag{28}$$

The sets $\mathcal{G}_o$, $\mathcal{D}_o$ and $\mathcal{C}_o$ select the contributions, and M_{ot} is the required minimum. Channel flow $R_{ct} = X_{ct}$ is signed. The inequality constrains existing flows and adds no water to the balances.

5 Operating constraints over time

A unit's initial operating state and its duration in that state are given. Binary starts s^+ and stops s^- record changes between consecutive intervals:

$$u_{gt} - u_{g,t-1} = s_{gt}^+ - s_{gt}^-, \quad s_{gt}^+ + s_{gt}^- \leq 1, \quad s_{gt}^{\pm} \in \{0, 1\}. \tag{29}$$

Minimum running time L_g^{up} means that a start at τ_t requires $u_{gk} \geq s_{gt}^+$ for each later interval with $0 \leq \tau_k - \tau_t < L_g^{\mathrm{up}}$. Minimum stopped time L_g^{down} similarly requires $u_{gk} \leq 1 - s_{gt}^-$ whenever $0 \leq \tau_k - \tau_t < L_g^{\mathrm{down}}$. These tests use elapsed hours, including on an irregular grid. Initial state age determines any remaining mandatory running or stopped time.

Apply these minimum-duration constraints to U if they are also specified for the plant. A handover between running units does not restart the plant. Any minimum duration unfinished at the horizon end becomes a requirement on the next schedule.

Availability, forced states and prescribed output restrict the same decisions:

$$\underline{u}_{gt} \leq u_{gt} \leq \overline{u}_{gt}, \quad P_{gt} = P_{gt}^{\mathrm{given}}, \quad q_{gt} = q_{gt}^{\mathrm{given}}. \tag{30}$$

We impose an output schedule only where one is supplied. Plant schedules constrain the sums of unit outputs, and plant state obeys $\underline{U}_{pt} \leq U_{pt} \leq \overline{U}_{pt}$. Maintenance requires units to be off. Zero scheduled output requires the off state, and positive output requires the on state. These constraints also apply during mandatory initial running or stopped periods. A conflict makes the model infeasible.

For interval-average discharge or release x_t, supplied upward and downward rates r_x^+, r_x^- limit changes between interval midpoints:

$$-\int_{m_{t-1}}^{m_t} r_x^-(s)\,\mathrm{d}s \leq x_t - x_{t-1} \leq \int_{m_{t-1}}^{m_t} r_x^+(s)\,\mathrm{d}s. \tag{31}$$

A running unit cannot enter its positive operating range from zero when the allowed inter-interval increase is smaller than its minimum output. We therefore allow a minimum-output jump at startup and shutdown in the power-ramp bounds. Add $\sum_{g \in \mathcal{G}_x} \underline{P}_{gt} s_{gt}^+$ to the upward allowance and $\sum_{g \in \mathcal{G}_x} \underline{P}_{g,t-1} s_{gt}^-$ to the downward allowance. Here $\mathcal{G}_x$ contains that unit or all units at the constrained plant. Discharge and river-release ramps have no jump allowance. For the first interval, use the average and midpoint of the supplied previous window. Omit that comparison if no previous window is supplied.

Reservoir volume and level ramps instead constrain vertex changes $V_{i,t+1} - V_{it}$ and $Z_i(V_{i,t+1}) - Z_i(V_{it})$, with rate integrals over $[\tau_t, \tau_{t+1}]$. The ramp limits apply between recorded states.
A tunnel interlock limits how many gates in a group $\mathcal{E}_\ell$ may be open at once. With $o_{et} = \mathbf{1}[b_{et} > 0]$,

$$\underline{N}_{\ell t} \le \sum_{e \in \mathcal{E}_\ell} o_{et} \le \overline{N}_{\ell t}. \tag{32}$$

A positive position counts as open even when its flow is zero.

Some handovers also require a plant shutdown after a gate closes. For each interlock, specify protected plants $\mathcal{P}_\ell$ and disjoint closure groups $\mathcal{E}_\ell^d \subseteq \mathcal{E}_\ell$, with d denoting forward or backward. Each group has a supplied waiting time $L_\ell^d \ge 0$ in hours. Closing its gate at τ_t requires every protected unit to be off during the wait:

$$\begin{gathered} u_{gk} + o_{e,t-1} - o_{et} \le 1, \quad \tau_t \le \tau_k < \tau_t + L_\ell^d, \\ e \in \mathcal{E}_\ell^d, \quad g \in \cup_{p \in \mathcal{P}_\ell} \mathcal{G}_p. \end{gathered} \tag{33}$$

At closure, the gate-status difference is one, so the inequality forces $u_{gk} = 0$. For every other transition it adds no restriction. It uses the existing variables, with initial gate status supplied before the first interval. Another intake may open immediately while the plant remains idle. Movement between positive positions is not a closure, and reopening does not cancel a wait. Controls change only at grid edges; a wait expiring inside an interval permits generation at the next edge.

A pre-horizon closure can leave a residual wait $w_{\ell d}^0$:

$$0 \le w_{\ell d}^0 \le L_\ell^d, \quad u_{gk} = 0 \quad \text{when} \quad \tau_k - \tau_0 < w_{\ell d}^0. \tag{34}$$

For a positive residual, the protected units must initially be off with off-age at least $L_\ell^d - w_{\ell d}^0$. This makes their histories consistent with the implied closure time. Zero declares no pending wait. On restart we retain the latest unexpired closure deadline in each group, together with the gate positions and unit histories. Closing a gate at the restart edge starts a new wait in the continuation.

6 Economic objective

Generation at price π_t per MWh earns $\pi_t \Delta_t P_{gt}$. Let c^+, c^- be unit transition costs, c^b nonnegative gate-movement costs, c^r nonnegative release-shortfall costs, and v_i, v_r the values assigned to water in reservoirs and reaches, per Mm^3. We maximize

$$\begin{aligned} \mathcal{V} = &\sum_t \pi_t \Delta_t \sum_g P_{gt} - \sum_{g,t} \left(c_{gt}^+ s_{gt}^+ + c_{gt}^- s_{gt}^- \right) \\ &- \sum_{e,t} c_{et}^b \left| b_{et} - b_{e,t-1} \right| - \sum_{r,t} c_{rt}^r \xi_{rt} \\ &+ \sum_i v_i (V_{iT} - V_{i0}) + \sum_r v_r (W_{rT} - W_{r0}). \end{aligned} \tag{35}$$

Starts, stops and gate movements are charged once per event, without a duration multiplier. The first gate comparison uses its supplied initial position. The last two terms value changes in reservoir storage and reach inventory. A late release can still have value downstream after the horizon ends. The terminal values v_i, v_r are inputs that account for this later use.

A positive release penalty permits a deficit below the entry minimum. The deficit variable is measured as a volume:

$$\xi_{rt} \ge 0, \quad \xi_{rt} \ge \kappa \Delta_t (R_{rt}^{\min} - R_{rt}). \tag{36}$$

A positive cost makes ξ equal the actual shortfall at optimum. Without that penalty, the entry minimum is hard and $\xi = 0$. Arrival minima and aggregate flow requirements remain hard. Subtracting the values of the initial inventories removes a constant from the reported objective and leaves the optimal decisions unchanged.

7 Solving the model and checking a schedule

7.1 Finding feasible controls

We build the models in JuMP [3]. SCIP first solves a MILP approximation to propose unit states and gate positions. We fix those choices and use Ipopt [4] to solve for the continuous decisions under the nonlinear hydraulic laws. The procedure may try several proposals within a time budget. Candidates that pass the checks below become starting solutions for the full SCIP search [5], which can change the discrete choices.

The MILP objective approximates (35) and gives no enclosing bound. Dispatch with the discrete choices fixed is a piecewise-smooth, nonconvex problem. A stationary solution need not be globally optimal.

7.2 Reconstructing the water trajectory

An independent integration holds the selected unit discharges and openings fixed and recovers the resulting water trajectory. At each interval, Newton's method solves jointly for ending storage, junction heads, tunnel flows and active outlet releases. With a delay shorter than the interval, some current release arrives before the interval ends and belongs in the same hydraulic solve. Equation (11) then gives electrical output.

In some isolated pressure components, the equations determine only head differences. A common shift in all heads leaves the flows unchanged. We choose one reference head for the numerical solve and keep every water balance. We can then shift the recovered heads to satisfy the junction bounds if the bounds admit such a shift.

We accept a reconstructed schedule only if it satisfies the interval equations and operating restrictions. We repeat the integration on a finer grid using the same controls. Schedules and ramps are checked over their original operating windows. We compare storage at the original vertices, total water, cumulative arrivals and terminal inventory. For the specified volume tolerance ε_V and relative objective tolerance $\varepsilon_{\mathcal{V}}$, the reconstruction must satisfy

$$\begin{gathered}\max_{i,t}\left|V_i^{\mathrm{fine}}(\tau_t)-V_{it}\right|\le\varepsilon_V,\quad \max_{r}\left|W_r^{\mathrm{fine}}(\tau_T)-W_{rT}\right|\le\varepsilon_V,\\ \left|\mathcal{V}^{\mathrm{fine}}-\mathcal{V}\right|\le\varepsilon_{\mathcal{V}}\max(1,|\mathcal{V}|).\end{gathered}\tag{37}$$

The comparison estimates the effect of time discretization for the chosen controls. It does not give a rigorous bound on continuous-time hydraulic error.

7.3 Bounding the remaining objective improvement

A feasible schedule gives an achievable objective value L. Global search provides an upper bound U that no feasible schedule in the declared model can exceed. SCIP obtains such bounds from relaxations, tightens them and branches on discrete choices or continuous variable ranges. A region can be discarded when its bound cannot improve the current feasible value.

A *relaxation* enlarges the feasible set. Its maximum is an upper bound on the scheduling objective because every feasible schedule is still in that set. The enlarged set may allow flow, head and efficiency values whose power exceeds the physical conversion law. A *valid inequality* holds for every feasible schedule and can exclude some of these excessive values.

The algebraic curve representations and bound constructions are given in Appendix A.

Here L is the independently reconstructed value of a schedule feasible for the interval model, and U must be a finite enclosing bound. The absolute and relative limits on possible improvement are

$$g_{\mathrm{abs}}=\max(0,U-L),\quad g_{\mathrm{rel}}=\frac{\max(0,U-L)}{\max(1,|L|)}.\tag{38}$$

If $L=100$ and $U=103$, improvement is limited to 3 monetary units, or 3% under this definition. There may be no better schedule at all. The constant subtraction of initial water values in (35) affects the relative gap's denominator, so L and U must use that same objective.

A certificate states that the requested absolute or relative gap has been met for the interval model, interpolation rules and finite gate sets. Fixing discrete choices makes the certificate conditional on those choices. A schedule may meet the interval-model gap and fail the finer-grid checks. Neither test

certifies a continuous-time optimum. The numerical certificate uses solver tolerances and floating-point bounds. It does not rigorously enclose every rounding error in the solver and polynomial calculations.

8 Discussion

The hydraulic equations let changes in reservoir levels and shared tunnel flows affect dispatch during optimization. River inventory accounts for released water until it reaches the next node. Using these nonlinear laws can be computationally expensive. Even with commitment fixed, the continuous problem is nonconvex, and a large network may take substantial time to close the objective gap.

Model accuracy also depends on the input curves. Finer integration can expose an inadequate time grid, but it cannot correct a miscalibrated efficiency or travel-time response. Tunnel positions absent from the declared finite set are excluded from the search. The objective certificate applies to this finite model, with its specified curves and control grid. Changing those assumptions requires solving a new problem.

Appendix

A Representing curves and strengthening bounds

The scheduling problem is a mixed-integer nonlinear program (MINLP). Fixing unit states and gate positions still leaves a nonconvex problem in flow, head, efficiency and travel response. SCIP needs algebraic equations for these functions and relaxations from which to compute upper objective bounds.

A.1 Representing supplied curves exactly

For a curve $y = f(x)$, the *graph* is the set of pairs (x, y) satisfying that equation. We reproduce the specified interpolant in the optimization model. Exactness here refers to the interpolant, not to the watercourse it approximates. A piecewise-linear curve with knots (x_i, y_i) has the graph

$$\lambda_i \geq 0, \quad \sum_i \lambda_i = 1, \quad x = \sum_i x_i \lambda_i, \quad y = \sum_i y_i \lambda_i, \quad \lambda \in \mathrm{SOS2}\,. \tag{39}$$

SOS2 restricts the weights to one segment [6]. The two neighboring weights sum to one, and the equation for x fixes the interpolation fraction. The equation for y then gives the interpolated output. Without adjacency, weights on distant knots could produce points away from the curve.

For a turbine table, discharge weights λ_i and head weights μ_j each satisfy the corresponding SOS2 and coordinate constraints. Let E_{ij} be efficiencies at the knots. Linear interpolation in head combines the values η_j on the neighboring head curves. For head-independent data, each head vertex uses the same efficiency column. A shape-preserving cubic in discharge [7] is represented by adding corrections to the linear curve:

$$\begin{gathered} w_i = \lambda_i \lambda_{i+1}, \quad r_i = \lambda_i w_i, \\ \eta_j = \sum_i E_{ij} \lambda_i + \sum_i \big[A_{ij} r_i + B_{ij} (w_i - r_i) \big], \quad \eta = \sum_j \mu_j \eta_j. \end{gathered} \tag{40}$$

For segment width $\delta q_i = q_{i+1} - q_i$, secant slope $d_{ij} = \big(E_{i+1,j} - E_{ij}\big)/\delta q_i$ and original endpoint derivatives m_{ij}, use

$$A_{ij} = \delta q_i \big(m_{ij} - d_{ij}\big), \quad B_{ij} = \delta q_i \big(d_{ij} - m_{i+1,j}\big). \tag{41}$$

On the active segment, the two correction terms are multiples of $\lambda_i^2 \lambda_{i+1}$ and $\lambda_i \lambda_{i+1}^2$. They vanish at the endpoints and adjust the derivatives to match the supplied slopes. The variables w_i, r_i express the corrections through quadratic equalities. Setting $A = B = 0$ gives bilinear interpolation. Restricting the curve's domain leaves its cubic slopes unchanged. We use the declared end secants for discharge outside the table and for head extrapolation where allowed.

An idle unit can have a network head outside its running table. A finite extension lets us evaluate the graph there. Its running head and efficiency limits are inactive, and $q = P = 0$.

Units with the same net-head variable and compatible table grids can share head weights. Each release cohort uses the same flow weights for arrivals, environmental checks and terminal inventory. Channel responses use a piecewise-bilinear graph. The product equalities in (40), (11) and (20) remain nonlinear.

A.2 Quadratic equations for tunnels and gates

A binary direction variable separates positive and negative tunnel flow:

$$\begin{gathered} Q = Q^+ - Q^-, \quad 0 \le Q^+ \le Cz, \quad 0 \le Q^- \le C(1-z), \\ S = (Q^+)^2 - (Q^-)^2, \quad z \in \{0,1\}. \end{gathered} \tag{42}$$

At $z = 1$, flow is nonnegative and $Q^- = 0$. At $z = 0$, flow is nonpositive and $Q^+ = 0$. This gives $S = Q|Q|$ in either case. Directed outfalls use $S = Q^2$. Known head ordering can also fix the direction.

For each finite gate position, a binary selector identifies whether that position is chosen. Exactly one selector is active, so b, the open state o and the selected resistance $K(b)$ are weighted sums of known values. To impose the loss equation only when the gate is open, define $d_o = o(H_v - H_w)$. If $L \le H_v - H_w \le U$, this binary product is represented by

$$Lo \le d_o \le Uo, \quad H_v - H_w - U(1-o) \le d_o \le H_v - H_w - L(1-o). \tag{43}$$

When $o = 0$, (43) forces $d_o = 0$. When $o = 1$, it forces $d_o = H_v - H_w$. Adding $|Q| \le Co$ and $d_o = K(b)S$ gives the open and closed gate laws in (6) and (7). The resistance assigned to the closed selector may be any finite value, since $S = 0$ there. All the product equalities are quadratic.

The outlet law also has a binary wet/dry branch for $\ell = \max(H - z^{\text{crest}}, 0)$. Its square root in (15) can be written using $r \ge 0$ and $r^2 = \ell$.

A.3 Upper bounds for global optimization

We bound variables using storage and equipment limits. Water balances propagate initial and terminal restrictions through the horizon to narrow these ranges. The bounds must hold for every admissible schedule.

We omit unit and time indices in the following bounds. For a running unit with nonnegative q, h, η, let $\overline{e}$ bound its electrical efficiency. Then $p^{\text{ub}}(q,h) = \gamma \overline{e} q h \eta(q,h)$ is an upper bound on physical electrical power. It is polynomial within each interpolation cell even when (11) is implicit in P. Suppose a plane $aq + bh + c$ bounds this polynomial throughout the running domain, with $b \ge 0$. For a head lower bound h_* valid in both operating states, the following inequality includes the idle state:

$$P \le aq + b(h - h_*) + (c + bh_*)u. \tag{44}$$

When the unit runs, it reduces to $P \le aq + bh + c$. When it is idle, $P = q = 0$ and the right side is nonnegative. To establish c, we bound the residual $p^{\text{ub}} - aq - bh$ over every original interpolation cell. In a Bernstein representation of a polynomial on a box, the basis weights are nonnegative and sum to one, so its value cannot exceed its largest coefficient. The coefficient bound covers the whole cell. Fitting a plane at a few samples alone could miss a larger residual between them.

A box containing the admissible running values of q, h, η has up to eight corners (q_c, h_c, η_c). We couple these variables with weights on the corners. Exact binary-product inequalities, as in (43), define $h_{\text{on}} = uh$ and $\eta_{\text{on}} = u\eta$. Nonnegative weights z_c on the corners satisfy

$$\begin{gathered} \sum_c z_c = u, \quad \sum_c q_c z_c = q, \quad \sum_c h_c z_c = h_{\text{on}}, \quad \sum_c \eta_c z_c = \eta_{\text{on}}, \\ \gamma e_{\min} \sum_c q_c h_c \eta_c z_c \le P \le \gamma e_{\max} \sum_c q_c h_c \eta_c z_c. \end{gathered} \tag{45}$$

Here $e_{\min}, e_{\max}$ bound electrical efficiency over the power range. For any point in the box, multilinear interpolation weights reproduce its coordinates and the product $qh\eta$. Hence the inequalities include every physical running point. When $u = 0$, all corner weights vanish. The original efficiency and power equalities still determine the physical output.

For a tabulated turbine, we can use its head knots h_j and weights μ_j to bound power. Define $\zeta_j = \mu_j$ for a running unit and $\zeta_j = 0$ for an idle unit through the following constraints:

$$0 \le \zeta_j \le \mu_j, \quad \sum_j \zeta_j = u, \quad \sum_j (h_j - h_1)\zeta_j = h_{\text{on}} - h_1 u, \\ P \le aq + \sum_j c_j \zeta_j. \tag{46}$$

The coefficients c_j are chosen so that the weighted expression bounds the polynomial upper bound p^{ub}, including its variation between head knots. The constraints give $\zeta = \mu$ when $u = 1$, and $\zeta = 0$ when $u = 0$ without fixing the idle hydraulic head. Discharge weights support analogous bounds along the other table axis. We may add further planes during the search after verifying each over its complete domain.

References

[1] J. P. S. Catalão, H. M. I. Pousinho, and V. M. F. Mendes, "Mixed-integer nonlinear approach for the optimal scheduling of a head-dependent hydro chain," *Electric Power Systems Research*, vol. 80, no. 8, pp. 935–942, 2010, doi: 10.1016/j.epsr.2009.12.015.

[2] J. C. I. Dooge, "A general theory of the unit hydrograph," *Journal of Geophysical Research*, vol. 64, no. 2, pp. 241–256, 1959, doi: 10.1029/JZ064i002p00241.

[3] I. Dunning, J. Huchette, and M. Lubin, "JuMP: A modeling language for mathematical optimization," *SIAM Review*, vol. 59, no. 2, pp. 295–320, 2017, doi: 10.1137/15M1020575.

[4] A. Wächter and L. T. Biegler, "On the implementation of an interior-point filter line-search algorithm for large-scale nonlinear programming," *Mathematical Programming*, vol. 106, pp. 25–57, 2006, doi: 10.1007/s10107-004-0559-y.

[5] S. Vigerske and A. Gleixner, "SCIP: global optimization of mixed-integer nonlinear programs in a branch-and-cut framework," *Optimization Methods and Software*, vol. 33, no. 3, pp. 563–593, 2018, doi: 10.1080/10556788.2017.1335312.

[6] J. Huchette and J. P. Vielma, "A combinatorial approach for small and strong formulations of disjunctive constraints," *Mathematics of Operations Research*, vol. 44, no. 3, pp. 793–820, 2019, doi: 10.1287/moor.2018.0946.

[7] F. N. Fritsch and J. Butland, "A method for constructing local monotone piecewise cubic interpolants," *SIAM Journal on Scientific and Statistical Computing*, vol. 5, no. 2, pp. 300–304, 1984, doi: 10.1137/0905021.